

The Discovery Interview: Why and What and the Topic List

Product Team Training

May 6, 2022



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	9			12	13	
	16					
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6 Why do it, what is it, getting started

9–12 You and your buddy write your topic list

13 Structure, details and tips, topic list critique

16–26 You and your buddy do an interview

27 Debrief



Topics

The aim of discovery
A core technique
With a core element
Your homework

Product team purpose

Seems familiar...

“Develop deep understanding of the markets we serve”

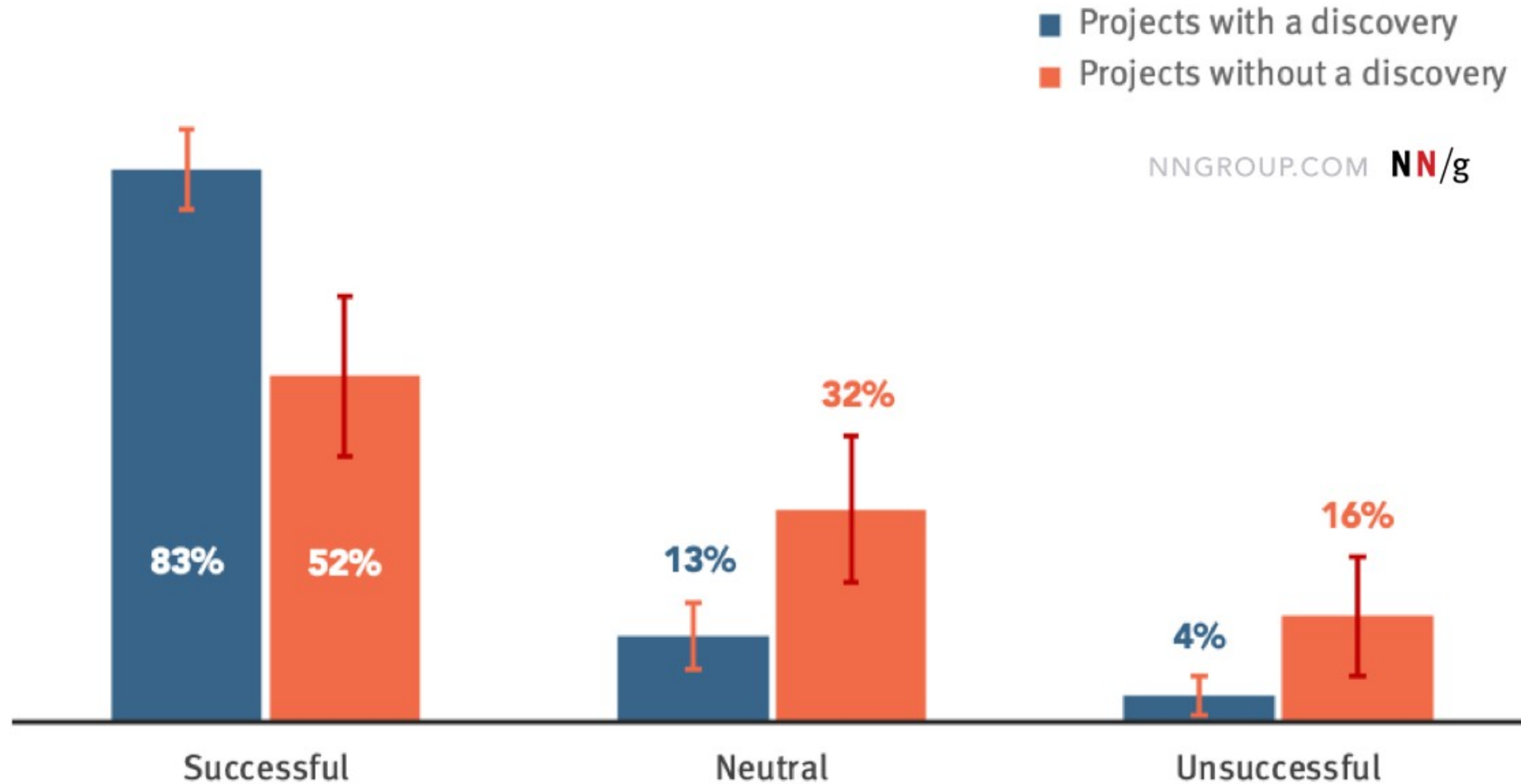
“Understand WHY customers are doing what they do”

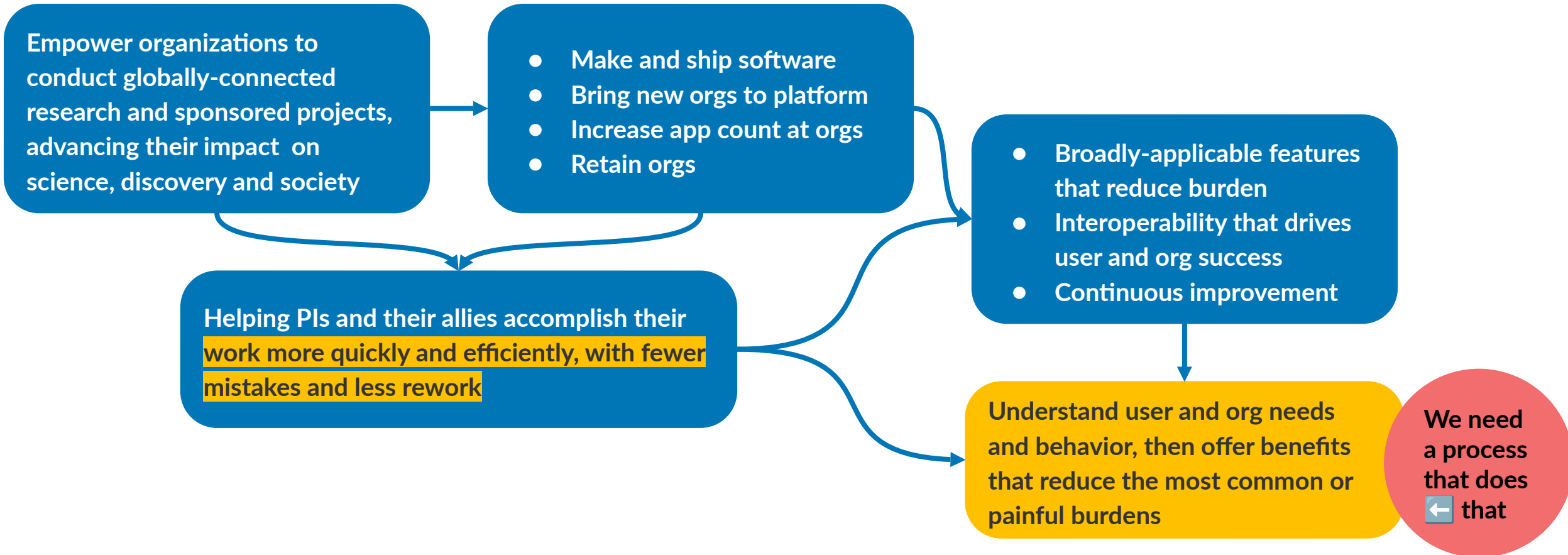
“(Have an) intense focus on solving real challenges of customers and end users”

“Leverage user interaction to drive ideas”

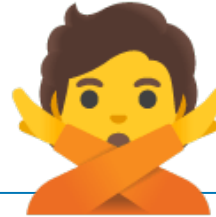


Reported Project Success for Projects with and Without Discoveries





Start/stop/continue



- **Start by piloting product discovery+ideation on a single new capability (kickoff with interviewing as the start of the process)**
- **Train on interviewing**
- **Framework for accomplishing interviews (how, when, step-by-step)**
- **Encourage to look at support traffic and community questions for opportunities**
- **NIHITO visits**
- **Use data to help inform/validate assumptions (leadership asks and expects)**
- **Other opportunities to make use of conference to learn from customers? (Innovation labs?)**

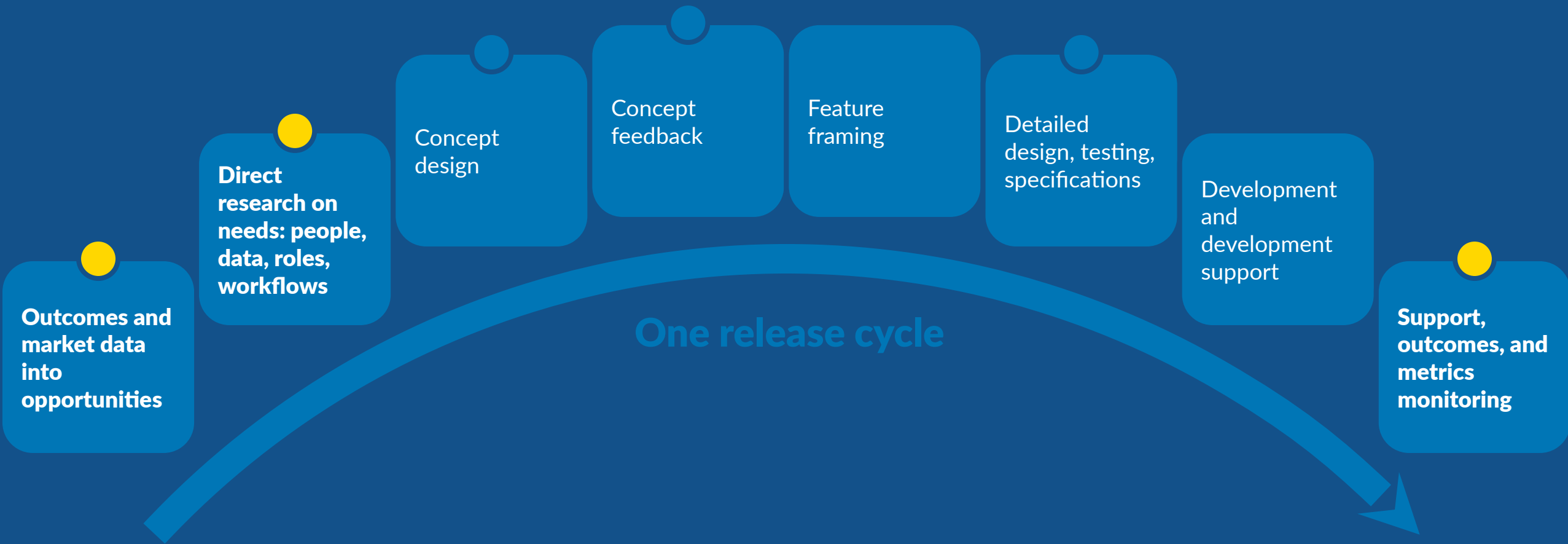
- **Beta testing and triaging in CAB**
- **Keeping customers warm on the future in CAB (but how to do this outside of CAB?)**
- **Steal some capacity from CAB for pilot project? Reduce frequency to 1Q from 1M?**
- **HMW move some tier 2 support and triaging out of the PM team?**
- **STAHP SELLING FUTURES, DAMMIT (Janet)**

- **Keep level of customer interaction high**
- **Product day (reinforce, set expectations about how to use that time)**
- **Set interview/customer contact level metric**
- **Product presents at conference**

We aren't and need to

It's not working or not worth it, or we kill it to make room for a "start"

We need to be sure not to stop, perhaps double-down



Three horizons

H2: early this or next release
Select and conceptually design individual features to deliver those benefits

H3: next and later releases
Understand user and org needs and behavior, offer and select benefits

H1: late this release
Detailed design and development of features

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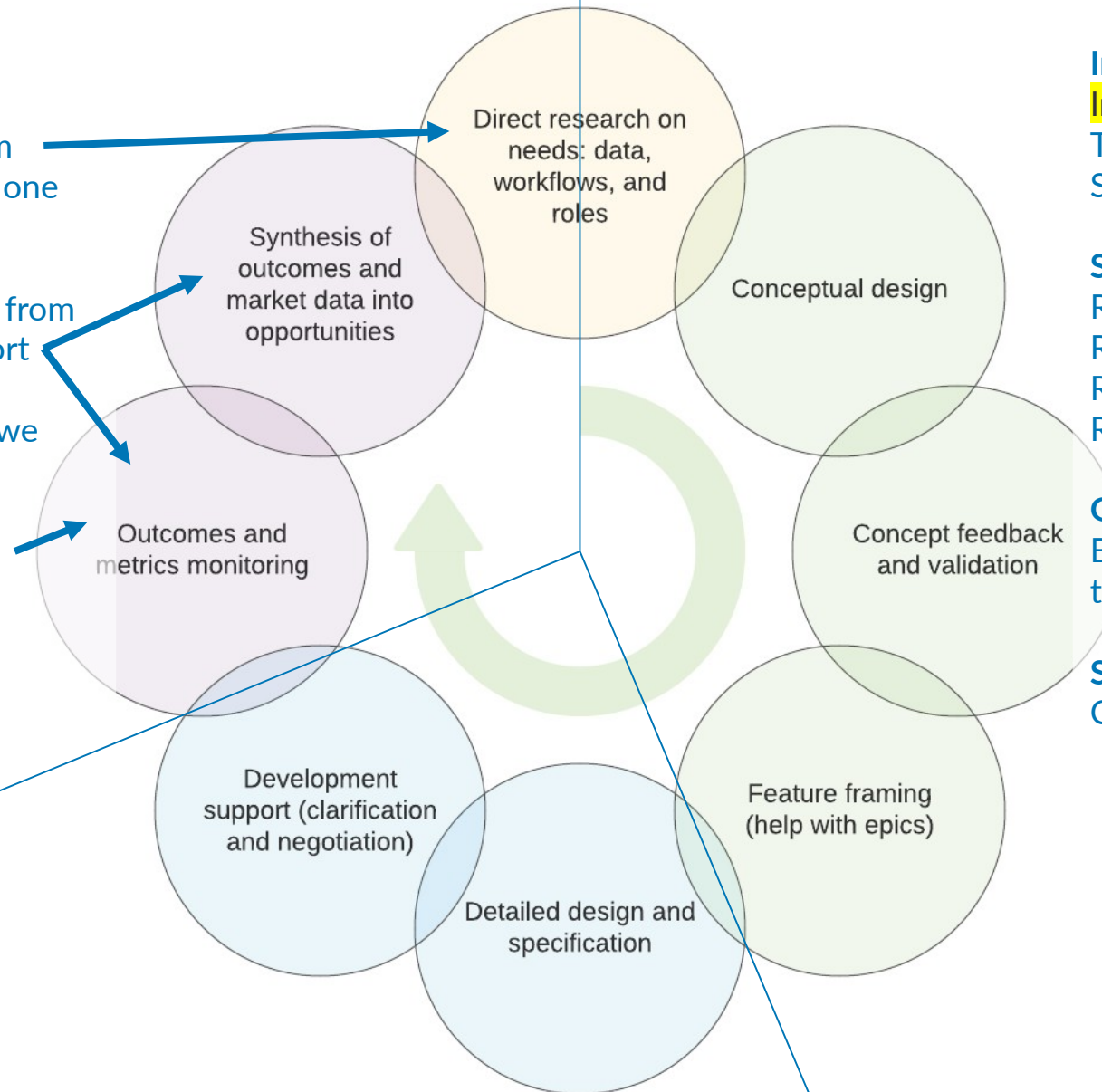
Determine IF and WHY a product/capability/feature should be developed, and what's important about it

Activities

New benefits to deliver come from examining the actual work being done and noticing ways we can help.

Improvement opportunities come from learning of current pains via support data, forum questions, summative testing, complaints, and how well we meet outcomes targets.

Since we determined outcomes to measure early, we can witness the success of the product.



Activities

Investigate Interviews

Task shadowing
Summative testing

Support/improve

Reviewing support data
Reviewing forum questions
Reviewing outcomes metrics
Reviewing sales demo questions/opps

Generate

Brainstorming and other generative techniques

Select/inform

CAB discussion of benefits

Activities Performed in Discovery Phases

(n=249)



NNGROUP.COM **NN/g**

Because

- Learn things we don't know
- Trip over hidden opportunities
- Feel the level of need
- Feel the level of potential impact
- Learn what is the hardest, what is broken
- Keep the *people who will use it* at the center

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- 
- A yellow, rectangular sticky note with a slight 3D effect and a drop shadow, tilted at an angle. It contains three bullet points.
- Conform(ish) to mental model
 - Be recommendable
 - Positive comments to decision-makers

Research Question



Understanding and learning

People, not product

Gaining new understanding

Gaining information we need

Answerable via interviews

Research Question



Research Question



Which design is best?

Is this usable?

Do people like it?

Will people buy it?

What do people want?

Is this feature valuable?

Research Question



~~Which design is best?~~

(A/B testing)

~~Is this usable?~~

(Usability testing)

~~Do people like it?~~

(Satisfaction survey)

~~Will people buy it?~~

(Product/market fit)

~~What do people want?~~

What is good and bad
about this process?

~~Is this feature valuable?~~

(Product/market fit)

Research Question



How can we help Type I diabetics manage their condition better?



How do Type I diabetics make decisions about their self-management, and what makes this process easier or more difficult?

How do we reduce support costs for our WiFi router product?



How do normal folks think about the setup of their WiFi router and where does our setup support or clash with their understanding?

Research Question



What new benefits should Cayuse Proposals offer users (so that they look forward to modernization)?



What difficulties linger in selecting and applying for opportunities and managing that portfolio?

Why does the developed product look so unsatisfyingly different from the UX specifications?



How do engineers and QA use the stories, specifications, and acceptance criteria, and where do deviations emerge in that process?

Behavioral



Behavioral



Attitudinal

Behavioral



Attitudinal



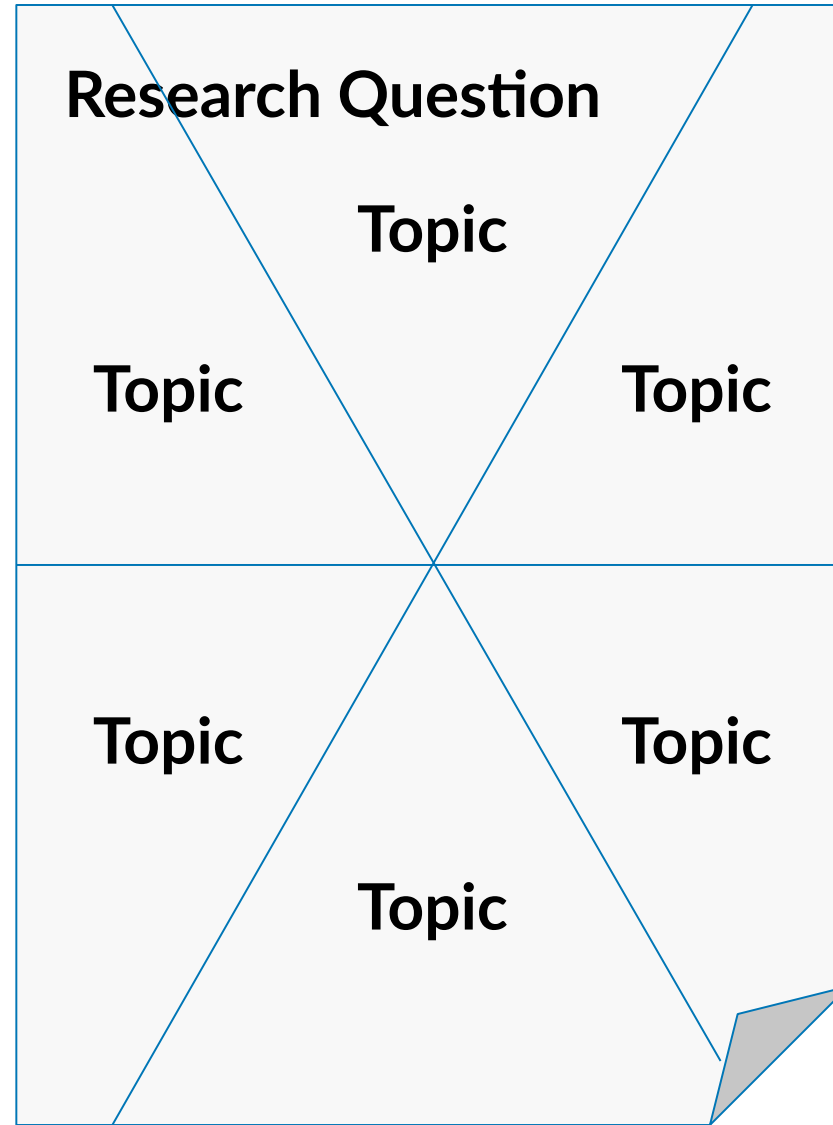
Research Question



How do [users] [think about/make decisions on/interact with] [subject of research/product]?

How do [users] perceive [process/event/concept]?

How do [users] perceive and report the impact of [process/event/concept]?



How do engineers and QA use the stories, specifications, and acceptance criteria, and where do deviations emerge in that process?



How many stories do you tackle in a given sprint? When you first get wind of a story, when is that? What happens from there?...

- information received
- artifacts looked at, order
- what artifacts are good and bad at communicating
- when there's a question/confusion
- when are you done
- complaints or compliments, from whom
- kinds of issues that come back to you
- gaps/incompleteness

Your homework

- Find a buddy
- What do you want to learn about?
- Write a research question
- Figure out who to interview, internal or external
- Write a topic list
- Bring your research question and topic list to the next session

The Discovery Interview: Accomplishing the Interview

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Topics

Interview personnel

Scheduling

Interview structure

Interview tips

Topic list discussion

Who

- 
- A photograph of three women sitting around a table in a modern office setting. One woman on the right is gesturing with her hand while speaking. The woman in the center is looking at her. The woman on the left is partially visible, looking down at a device. The background shows a window with a view of a building.
- Ideally, *two* interviewers
 - One to run the interview, ask questions, maintain rapport
 - One to take notes, make sure we hit all areas of the topic list, manage the speed of the interview, ask clarifying questions, watch the clock
 - Ideally, *one* interviewee
 - Two can be done if one is considered primary
 - A group session is not an interview

Scheduling

- Try to schedule a week in advance
- Offer dates and times to choose from
- Explain the general topic so the interviewee can be ready to chat about it
- Remind them that there's no homework, nothing to prepare
- Say how long it will take (45 min is about when fatigue will start to appear, so keep it to under 60 min)
- Meet them at a quiet location they are comfortable in (in person) or ask them to be in a quiet place (phone/Zoom) to reduce distractions



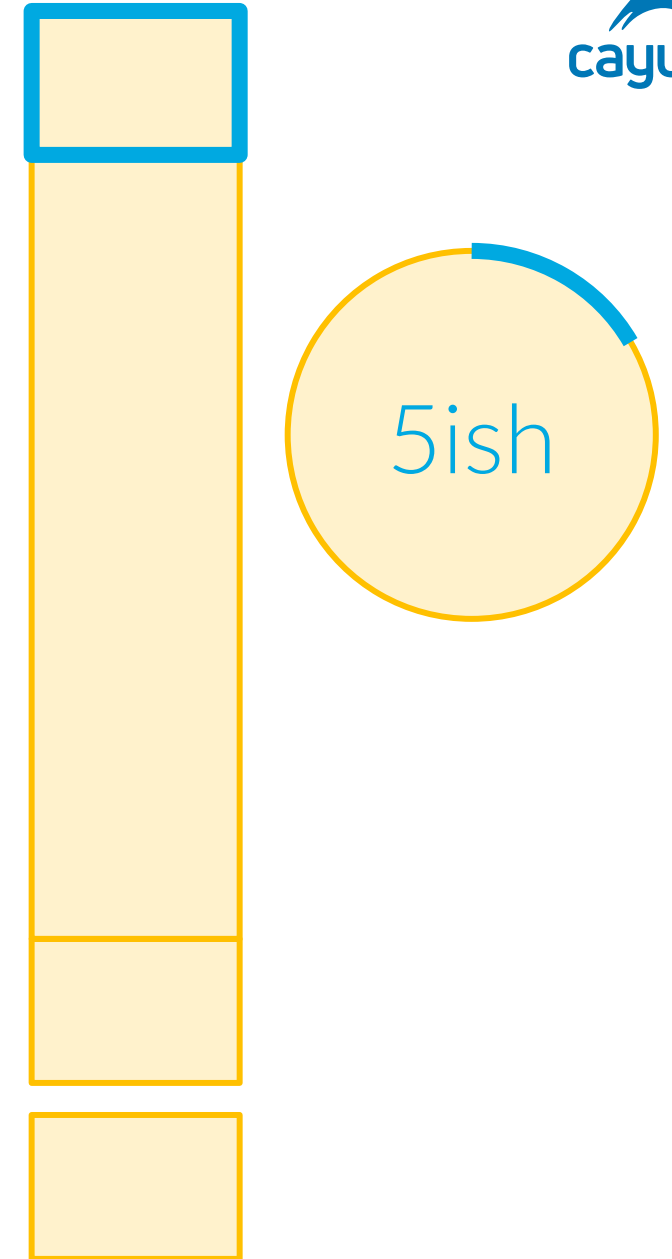
Structure

- **Opening** – Administrative stuff and begin to establish rapport
- **Discussion** – Further rapport and learn **from the interviewee via open-ended questions and discussion**
- **Closing** – Wrap it up, thanks
- **Debrief** – Consolidate learnings and check how it went



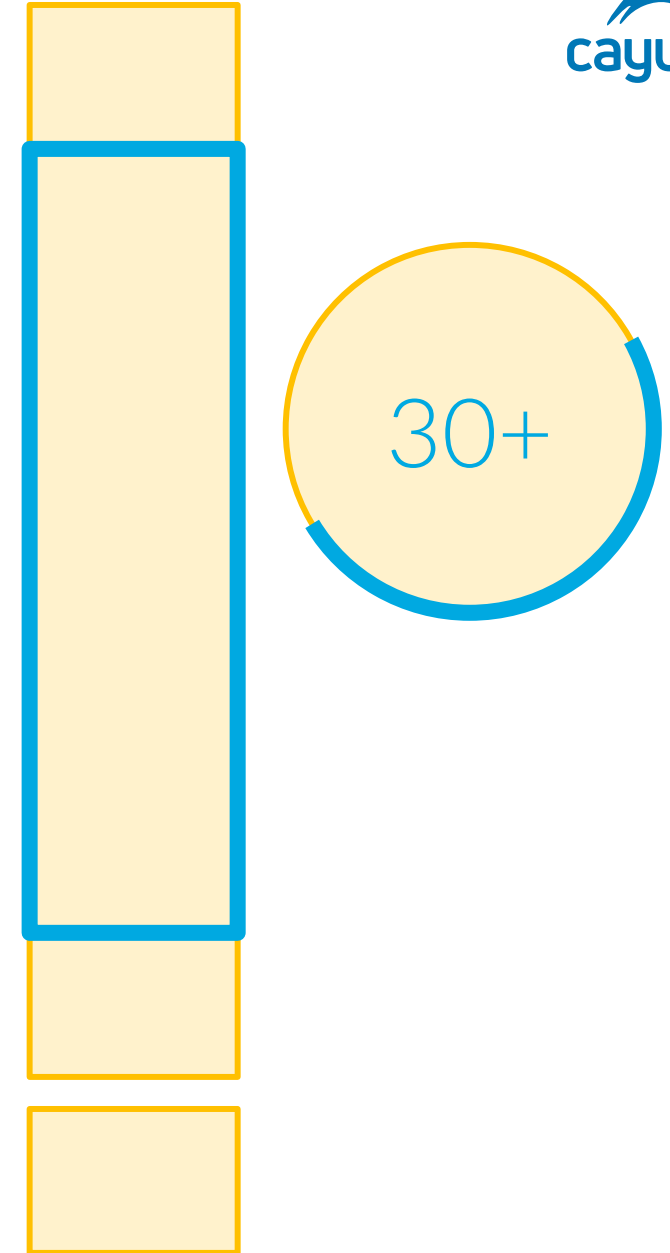
Structure – Opening

- Introduce yourselves
 - Name, title
 - Ask how they are
- Purpose of the interview
- Your roles in the interview
- Remind them of the timeframe
- Check that all of this is alright (further establishes consent to the interview)
- Gain consent (or not) to recording
 - Supported by how it will be used (and not)



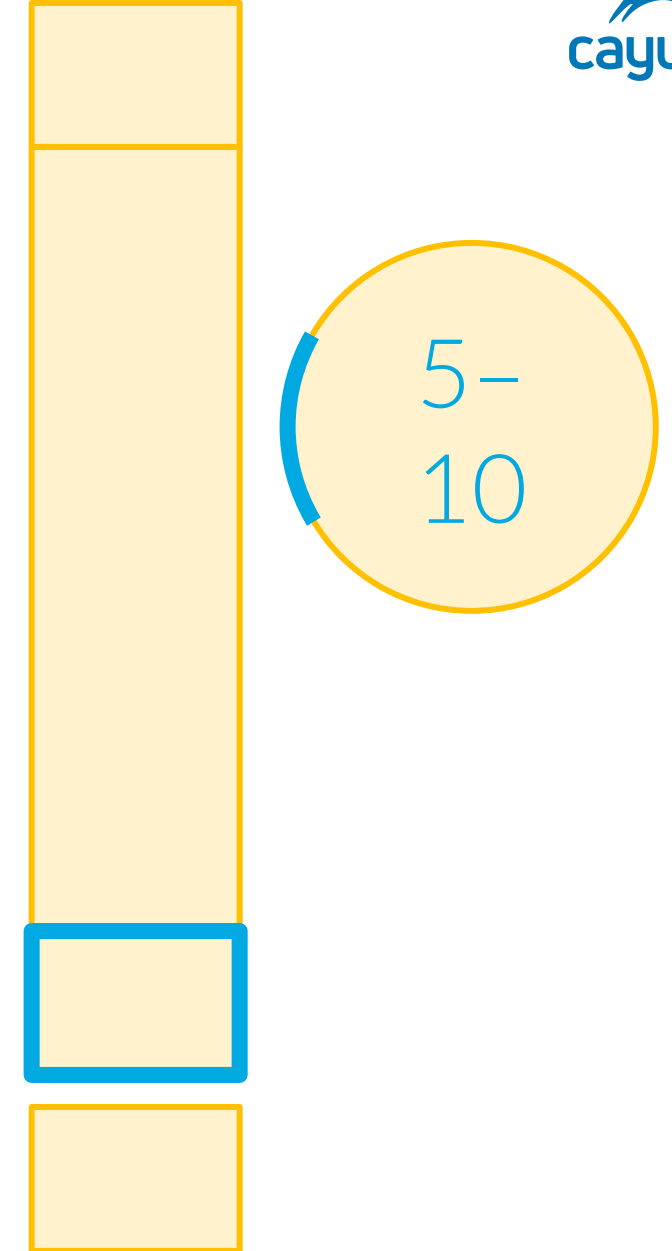
Structure – Discussion

- Open with the “further rapport” questions
- This is where you get into your topic list
- Interviewer works from topic list flexibly
- Notetaker helps make sure things are clear, nothing is missed outright
- Tips in a moment...



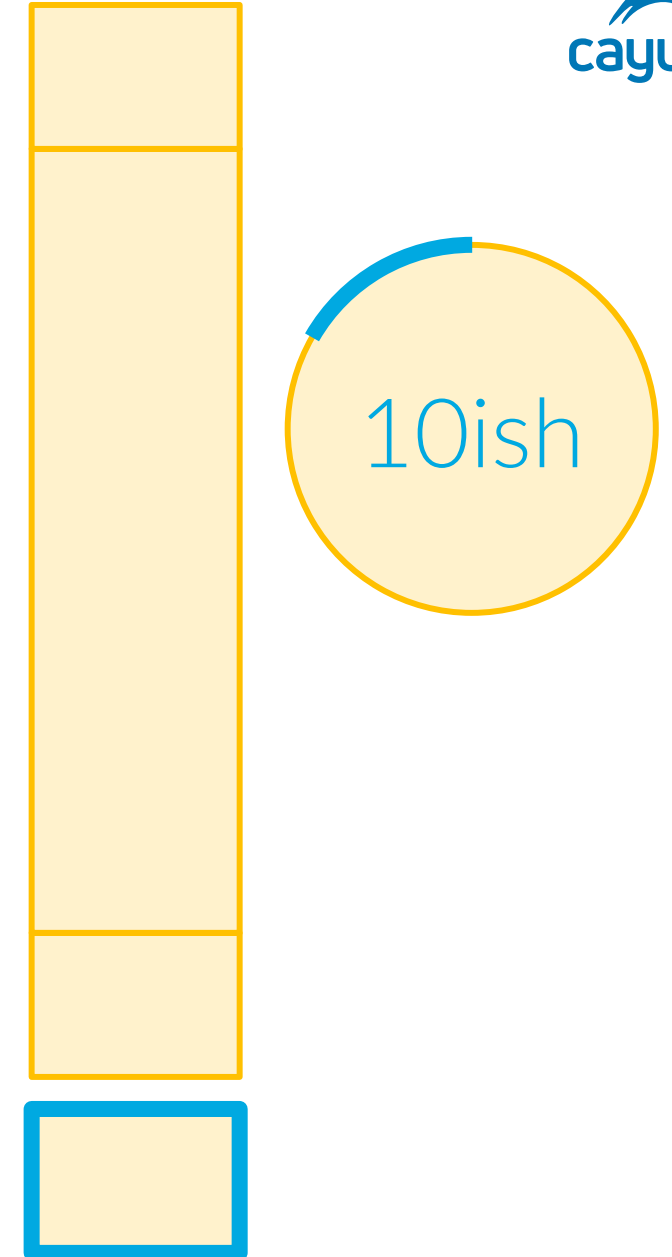
Structure – Closing

- Time check (notetaker)
- Ask a last question if there's time
- Ask for permission to email for possible follow-up questions
- Thank them for the information/their help



Structure – Debrief

- ASAP after the interview! Don't skip it!
- Go over notes and impressions
 - What stood out in what was said
 - What you learned
 - What was different from other interviews
 - What you remain curious about
- Also discuss how the interview went



Tips: question styles

All but the earliest questions in an interview should be open-ended. Start with some relevant closed-ended questions to further rapport, then open up.

You can use closed-ended questions in a limited way if needed to get into specifics or re-start a stalled conversation.

Closed-ended

- Is it OK if we record this session?
- How many proposals does your office handle in a month?

Open-ended

- When a proposal comes back for re-work, what's typically wrong with it?
- Once a proposal comes to your desk, what needs to be done with it?
- Whose hands does a proposal go through during its lifecycle?

Tips: establishing and furthering rapport

Easy and friendly questions at the beginning start establishing rapport.

Topical questions that are **closed-ended**, and that lead to related **open-ended** questions, help further rapport. You should have some “furthering rapport” questions at the top of your topic list.

- How are you today?
- Is it alright if we record this?
- What’s your title? Does it accurately describe your role?
- How many proposals does your office handle in a day?
- Wow, that’s a lot. How do you deal with such volume?

Tips: getting more information

Easy “get more detail” questions are especially useful when going into behavior, process, or feelings.

Focusing on a specific recent example can help.

If it’s handy, could we see one?

How often does that happen? When was the last time? What happened then?

Say more about that?

Could you explain that again?

Tips: changing subject/getting back on track



It's okay to change the subject to end a tangent, move along the topic list, etc.

There's a thing you mentioned earlier that I'd like to return to...

I'd like you to talk about...

Before we run out of time, can you tell me...

How does that relate to...

Tips: expansive questions

Use expansive questions, late in an interview, to broaden thinking and connect process to feeling.

If you were a superhero of [thing], what would you be able to do?

What makes a day an especially good day [as a role/doing a thing]? When it's a bad day, what does that look like?

Is there one stupid problem/issue/task that you wish would just get fixed/go away?

Tips: the under-responsive interviewee

Fall back to more factual, descriptive questions if you're having a hard time getting the interviewee to talk. But don't close them down entirely.

Walk me through the steps when...

How often does that happen? When was the last time? What happened then?

The most recent time you [did thing], what happened first? Then?

What decisions do you typically need to make about [thing/process]?

Your new homework

- Plan and schedule an interview
- Accomplish an interview
- Debrief immediately afterward
- Document the findings (at least make your notes readable and informative for later)
- Think about what went well or poorly so we can discuss at our debrief meeting